TEN DEVOTIONALS ON THE BOOK OF JONAH

Journey through Jonah

Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé

How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the Hebrew text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Journey through Jonah
Ten devotionals on the book of Jonah

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/jona/en/

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DAY 1

The Call to Nineveh and the Flight to Tarshish

SCRIPTURE

Jonah 1:1–3

[1] The word of the LORD came to Jonah son of Amittai: [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, the great city, and cry out against it, for their evil has come up before my face." [3] So Jonah got up – to flee to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD. He went down to Joppa and found a ship bound for Tarshish. He paid the fare and went down into it, to go with them to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

The book of Jonah stands apart among the Twelve Minor Prophets. The other prophetic books mostly record the sermons and visions of their prophets. Jonah, by contrast, is a masterfully told prophetic **story** – about the prophet himself. Here God holds up a mirror not only to a sinful world, but to his own servants.

Jonah son of Amittai was no fictional character. We meet him in **2 Kings 14:25**, ministering in the reign of King Jeroboam II of Israel (about 786–746 BC). He came from Gath Hepher in Galilee and preached a popular message: territorial expansion and national prosperity for the northern kingdom. Jonah was a patriot – a man who loved his people and was used to announcing God's favour over Israel.

Then God's voice breaks into his comfortable ministry with a shocking command: "**Go to Nineveh, the great city.**" Nineveh was one of the capitals, and the very symbol, of the Assyrian Empire – the most brutal and feared superpower of the ancient Near East. The Assyrians were notorious

for their cruelty: they flayed captives alive, burned cities to the ground, and proudly carved their war atrocities into palace walls. For an Israelite in the eighth century BC, a command to go to Nineveh was not merely dangerous. It felt like betraying your own people.

Instead of travelling some 800 kilometres north-east to Nineveh, in today's Iraq, Jonah turns on his heel and runs for **Tarshish** – probably Tartessos on the southern coast of Spain, some 4,000 kilometres to the west, at the far edge of the known world.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

These first three verses are packed with literary irony and theological depth:

- **Jonah son of Amittai (*Yonah ben-Amittai* – יוֹנָה בֶּן־אֲמִתַּי):** *Yonah* means "**dove**", and *Amittai* comes from *emet* (אֱמֶת), "**truth**" or "**faithfulness**". In Israel the dove was a picture of peace – and sometimes of a silly, fluttering bird (see Hosea 7:11). The book's deepest irony is already in the name: the "Dove, son of Truth" refuses to carry God's peace and truth to the nations.
- **"Get up, go" (*qum, lekh* – קוּם לֵךְ):** This is the classic, urgent command to a prophet. Verse 3 picks up the same verb with biting irony: "*So Jonah got up*" (*wayyaqom*) – "to *flee* to *Tarshish*." Jonah does get up. He uses exactly the energy and opportunity God gives him – but runs in the opposite direction.
- **"He went down" (*yarad* – יָרַד):** The verb *yarad*, "to go down", is the backbone of chapters 1 and 2. Geographically, you really did go down from Israel's hill country to the port of Joppa. But the narrator deliberately turns it into a spiritual motif: Jonah goes **down** to Joppa (v. 3), **down** into the ship (v. 3), **down** into the innermost part of the ship to sleep (v. 5), and finally **down** to the roots of the mountains on the sea floor (2:7;

English Bibles 2:6). Every step away from God's call is a step downward. Even Nineveh's evil has "come up" (v. 2) – it rises to God, while his prophet goes down away from him.

- **"Away from the face of the LORD" (*millifnei* YHWH – מִלִּפְנֵי יְהוָה):** Verse 3 says it twice. As a trained prophet, Jonah knew psalms like Psalm 139: *"Where could I go from your Spirit? Where could I flee from your face?"* (Ps 139:7). He knew full well that God is everywhere. But "to stand before the face of the LORD" was the set phrase for a prophet's active service (see 1 Kings 17:1). In effect, Jonah is handing in his resignation. He thinks that if he leaves Israel, he can walk away from his calling.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's sovereign compassion overruns our boundaries.** Nineveh's evil has "come up before" God's face (v. 2). God does not ignore sin – he sees Nineveh's injustice clearly. But by sending a prophet to warn them, he already shows that he wants to be gracious (as Jonah himself admits in 4:2). God's heart beats for people we have long since written off.
2. **The anatomy of spiritual rebellion.** Jonah doesn't run because he doubts that God exists. He runs precisely because he knows exactly who God is – and disagrees with God's gracious plan. Our hardest crises of obedience often come not when we fail to understand God, but when we understand his will crystal-clear and still prefer our own.
3. **The deception of "favourable circumstances".** When Jonah reaches Joppa, a ship for Tarshish just happens to be waiting, and he just happens to have enough money for the fare. We often assume that an "open door" automatically proves God's blessing. Sometimes the ship waiting in Joppa is not God's provision but a test of our heart.
4. **The high cost of running.** The text makes a point of it: *"He paid the fare."* When you walk in God's commission, he provides for the journey. When you run from God, you always pay the fare yourself – and, as we will see, you never even reach the destination you paid for.

Living It Out

Each of us has a **Nineveh** and a **Tarshish** in our life of faith.

Your *Nineveh* is the place, the person or the task God is calling you to that makes you deeply uncomfortable. It may be the person who hurt you, whom you need to pray for and forgive. It may be a difficult conversation you keep putting off, a sin you need to confess, or a call to serve people you don't like, far outside your comfort zone. We would like God to bless only our "Gath Hepher" – our own circle, our own plans, our own comfort. But when his Word challenges our prejudices, we dig in our heels against his voice.

Your *Tarshish* is your escape route. Nobody today needs to board a wooden ship to flee from God's presence. We run to Tarshish through constant busyness, endless distraction on our screens, overwork, emotional withdrawal – or even by keeping ourselves occupied with other "good" church activities, just so we don't have to do the one specific thing the Lord is asking of us.

Beware, too, of rationalising disobedience. When you walk away from God's clear voice and everything still goes smoothly, don't mistake calm for peace – it may be spiritual numbness. The ship to Tarshish always sails easily out of the harbour. The storm is waiting on the open sea.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What is my "Nineveh" right now?** What specific task, conversation, act of forgiveness or step of faith has the Lord laid on my heart that I am deliberately avoiding because it threatens my pride or my comfort?
- **What "Tarshish" am I using to hide?** What keeps my mind and my calendar so full that I never have to become still before the Lord?
- **Where am I mistaking convenient circumstances for God's will?** Have I recently justified a compromise simply because the opportunity came so easily?

- **Are there people or groups I secretly begrudge God's grace?** What is my attitude towards those I see as "enemies" or outsiders?

Prayer

> *Lord, almighty and merciful God, I bow before you honestly today. You know my heart better than I know it myself. Like Jonah, I am so often eager to receive your blessing and hear your voice when it fits my own plans and comfort – and so quick to shrink back when you send me to my own "Nineveh".*
>
> *Forgive me for the times I hear what you are asking, then turn and go my own way. Forgive me for the selfish boundaries I try to draw around your grace, and for the times I think I can lock my heart against your presence. Shake me awake today wherever I am "going down" – away from your call and away from closeness with you.*
>
> *Give me the courage to tear up my ticket to Tarshish. Break my stubbornness, and replace my prejudice and fear with your own compassionate Father's heart. Make me willing to get up and go wherever you send me, knowing that your presence is my greatest safety. In the name of Jesus Christ, who did not run away, but set his face resolutely towards the cross to save me. Amen.*

DAY 2

The Storm of Grace and the Sleeping Prophet

SCRIPTURE
Jonah 1:4–10

4 But the LORD hurled a great wind onto the sea, and there was a great
storm on the sea, so that the ship threatened to break apart. 5 The
sailors were afraid, and each cried out to his own god. They hurled the
cargo that was in the ship into the sea to lighten it for themselves. But
Jonah had gone down into the innermost part of the ship, had lain
down, and had fallen into a deep sleep. 6 The captain came to him and
said to him, "What are you doing asleep? Get up, call out to your god!
Perhaps that god will give a thought to us, and we will not perish."
7 Then they said to one another, "Come, let us cast lots, so that we may
know on whose account this evil has come upon us." So they cast lots,
and the lot fell on Jonah. 8 Then they said to him, "Tell us, please, on
whose account this evil has come upon us! What is your work, and
where do you come from? What is your country, and from what people
are you?" 9 He said to them, "A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of
heaven, I fear – he who made the sea and the dry land." 10 Then the men
feared with a great fear and said to him, "What is this you have done!"
For the men knew that he was fleeing from the face of the LORD, because
he had told them.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Jonah has paid his fare and thinks the hardest part of his escape is behind him. But verse 4 opens with two of the most powerful words in the Bible: "**But the** LORD **...**" Jonah made the first move, but God has the last word.

The sailors on this merchant ship (probably hardened Phoenician seamen) were experienced men of the Mediterranean. They were used to storms, but this one was of a completely different order. Their sheer panic shows in the fact that they throw the cargo overboard – they literally destroy the whole financial point of their dangerous voyage just to stay afloat.

As a storyteller, the author sets up a shocking contrast between the **pagan sailors** and the **prophet of the covenant**:

- The sailors pray fervently to their gods; Jonah's lips stay sealed.
- The sailors fight on deck to save lives; Jonah hides away below.
- The pagans show compassion and respect for life; the man of God is cold and indifferent to their fate.

When every human effort fails, the sailors turn to casting lots – a common practice in the ancient Near East (shaking marked pebbles or sticks) to find out who had angered the gods. What was a desperate custom for the sailors, the sovereign God of Israel uses to expose his runaway prophet (see Proverbs 16:33).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew word choices in this passage paint an unforgettable picture of God's power set against Jonah's spiritual numbness:

- **"Hurled" (*hetil* – הֵטִיל):** The text doesn't simply say a wind got up. The LORD "hurled" a great wind onto the sea, like a warrior throwing a spear. This exact verb appears four times in chapter 1: God *hurls* the wind (v. 4), the sailors *hurl* the cargo into the sea (v. 5), Jonah tells them to *hurl* him into the sea (v. 12), and they *hurl* him overboard (v. 15). Even the forces of nature are just instruments in God's hand.
- **"Threatened to break apart" (*chishshevah lehishshaver* – חִשְּׁבָה לְהִשָּׁבֵר):** Our translation says the ship "threatened to break apart". Literally, the Hebrew says: "*the ship thought about breaking*." A masterly personifica-

tion! Even the lifeless planks of the ship feel the weight of God's anger and respond to it – while the prophet of God lies below deck feeling nothing.

- **"Fallen into a deep sleep" (*wayyeradam* – וַיֵּרָדַם):** This word comes from the root *radam*, which describes a deep, drugged, almost coma-like sleep. The same root gives us the "deep sleep" God caused to fall on Adam in Genesis 2:21. This was not the peaceful sleep of a clear conscience, but the paralysed, escapist sleep of someone sunk in spiritual depression and denial. The captain even calls him a *nirdam* – a "sleeper".
- **"Get up, call out!" (*qum, qera* – קוּם קְרָא):** When the pagan captain shakes Jonah awake in verse 6, he uses in Hebrew *exactly the same two commands* the LORD gave Jonah in verse 2: *"Get up (qum) ... and cry out (qera) against it!"* What irony: Jonah runs so as not to hear God's voice, and now God's original command echoes back to him from the mouth of a pagan seaman.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The storm as an act of grace.** The worst thing God could do to a disobedient child would be simply to let him walk his own road to ruin. This storm was not meant to drown Jonah but to turn him around. God's discipline is always rooted in his unfailing covenant love (Hebrews 12:6).
2. **Sin never affects only you.** We often think our private disobedience is just between us and the Lord. But Jonah's rebellion drags a whole crew of innocent people into a deadly crisis and costs them their livelihood. When believers fall asleep spiritually, the world around them suffers.
3. **The danger of dead orthodoxy.** In verse 9 Jonah makes a beautiful, catechism-perfect confession: *"A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of heaven, I fear – he who made the sea and the dry land."* The theology in his

head is 100% right, but his life is 100% wrong. If he really believed God made the sea, why did he try to escape by sea? Even the pagan sailors see the contradiction at once and cry out: *"What is this you have done!"*

Living It Out

When we run from God's will, we often react exactly like Jonah: we lie down in the innermost part of our lives and **fall asleep spiritually** (*radam*). Sin and disobedience are spiritually exhausting. To cope with the guilt and the strain of our rebellion, we numb ourselves. For some, that is literal sleep and depressive withdrawal; for others, an emotional dullness in which we simply stop caring about the needs of the people around us.

Meanwhile the storm rages outside. Your family, your colleagues or your community may be going through deep waters while you – who know the true God and have the power of prayer – are spiritually absent. How shameful when the world, like the captain, has to shake the church awake and ask: *"How can you sleep while we are perishing? Call out to your God!"*

This passage also makes us look at our own confession. It is easy to speak the right Christian language on Sunday, to declare that we "fear the Lord", while on Monday our feet are still on the ship to Tarshish. But praise the Lord for his gracious storms! If there is unexplained headwind and unrest in your life right now because you have turned away from his voice, know this: God does not hate you. He loves you too much to let you sail peacefully to Tarshish.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Am I in a "storm of grace" right now?** Is there an area of unrest, frustration or headwind through which the Lord is trying to get my attention and call me back from a wrong course?
- **Where have I fallen asleep spiritually?** Have I become apathetic and cold towards the spiritual and practical needs of the people closest to me – my family, workplace or community?

- **Who is being hurt by my disobedience?** Which "sailors" in my life are carrying the heavy consequences of my stubbornness, anger or spiritual absence?
- **Does my life match my lips?** If people compared my daily choices with my confession that I fear the Lord, would it stir faith in them – or the shocked question: "*What is this you have done?*"

Prayer

> *Lord, Maker of heaven, the sea and the dry land, I stand amazed today at how far you are willing to go to bring a runaway child home. Thank you for not leaving me to my own rebellion. Thank you for every storm of grace that shakes my false security and makes me see how empty my escapes are without you.*
>
> *Lord, I confess that so often I know all the right spiritual words. With my mouth I can confess that I fear you and know your power, while my heart is cold and my ears are closed to your commands. Forgive me for my spiritual slumber. Forgive me for the times I sink into apathy and self-pity, blind and deaf to the people around me who are going under in the storms of life.*
>
> *Shake me awake today, Lord! Let your voice break through my numbness. Bring me up out of the dark hold of my own excuses and down onto my knees before you. Make my life and my confession one again, to the honour of your name and the rescue of the people around me. Amen.*

DAY 3

The Sacrifice in the Waves and the Sailors' Worship

SCRIPTURE

Jonah 1:11–16

11 And they said to him, "What shall we do to you, so that the sea will
calm down for us?" For the sea was growing more and more stormy.
12 He said to them, "Pick me up and hurl me into the sea, and the sea will
calm down for you. For I know that it is on my account that this great
storm has come upon you." 13 The men rowed hard to get back to dry
land, but they could not, for the sea was growing more and more stormy
against them. 14 Then they called out to the LORD and said, "Please, LORD,
do not let us perish for this man's life, and do not lay innocent blood on
us! For you, LORD, have done as you pleased." 15 Then they picked Jonah
up and hurled him into the sea, and the sea stopped its raging. 16 Then
the men feared the LORD with a great fear; they offered a sacrifice to the
LORD and made vows.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we reach the dramatic climax of the first chapter. After Jonah has confessed in verse 9 that he fears the Maker of the sea and the dry land, the helpless sailors turn to him for an answer: "*What shall we do to you*?" They recognise that this storm is beyond human strength, and that only the prophet of Yahweh knows what Yahweh requires.

Jonah's answer in verse 12 – "*Pick me up and hurl me into the sea*" – looks noble at first glance. But read against the background of the whole book, it reveals a complex mix of guilt and continued resistance. Jonah honestly admits that he is the cause of the disaster, and he doesn't want the sailors

to die because of him. Yet he still refuses to fall on his knees on deck, ask forgiveness and promise to go to Nineveh. He would literally rather drown in the sea than obey God's call to go to his enemies!

But notice the striking contrast in verse 13: even after Jonah has given them a way out, these rough pagan seamen at first refuse to sacrifice his life. They spend their last strength rowing against the hurricane to spare Jonah. The pagans show more grace, more respect for human life and more humanity towards one guilty Hebrew than the prophet of God is willing to show the whole city of Nineveh.

As literature, verses 14–16 form a mirror image of the start of the storm in verse 5:

- In verse 5 the sailors are **afraid** of the storm; in verse 16 they **fear** the LORD with holy awe.
- In verse 5 each cries out to **his own god**; in verse 14 they call out together to **the LORD (Yahweh)**.
- In verse 5 they hurl the **cargo** overboard and it doesn't help; in verse 15 they hurl **Jonah** overboard and are rescued at once.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text portrays the tension between human helplessness and divine power with remarkable force:

- **"More and more stormy" (*holekh wesoer* – הוֹלֵךְ וְסוֹעֵר):** This idiom appears in both verse 11 and verse 13 and literally means: *"the sea was going and storming."* It describes a progressive, unstoppable build-up of violence. Every minute of delay makes the waves climb higher.
- **"Rowed hard" (*wayyachteru* – וַיַּחְתְּרוּ):** Our translation says the men "rowed hard", but the Hebrew verb *chatar* literally means **"to dig"** or **"to break through a wall"** (as in Ezekiel 12:5 and Amos 9:2). It is a gripping

image: the sailors drive their oars like spades into towering walls of water and desperately try to "dig" their way to the dry land – *yabbashah*, the very word Jonah used in verse 9.

- **"Stopped its raging" (*wayyaamod mizzapo* – וַיַּעֲמֹד מִזַּעְפּוֹ):** The word *zaaf* means fierce anger or rage. Literally it says: *"And the sea stood still from its fury."* Just as later, when Jesus rebuked the storm on the Sea of Galilee (Mark 4:39), the churning swell doesn't die down over hours – it goes dead calm in an instant.
- **"Feared the LORD with a great fear" (*wayyireu haanashim yirah gedolah et*-YHWH – וַיִּירְאוּ הָאֲנָשִׁים יִרְאָה גְדוֹלָה אֶת־יְהוָה):** While the storm raged, they were afraid; when the deathly calm fell, then they were truly terrified! Why? Because they realised they were standing in the immediate presence of the living God, who holds all creation under his authority. Their panic turns into worship – *a sacrifice and vows*.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The futility of "rowing harder" against God's will.** Verse 13 is the timeless picture of human beings trying to solve a spiritual crisis with human sweat. You can "dig" in the waves of life until your arms give out, but human effort can never take the place of surrender to God's word.
2. **God's sovereign freedom.** In their prayer in verse 14 the sailors confess: *"For you, LORD, have done as you pleased."* In a world of fickle nature gods, these converted seamen proclaim the heart of biblical theology: Yahweh reigns sovereign over good and evil, over wind and human destiny (Psalm 115:3).
3. **Christ, the one greater than Jonah (substitutionary atonement).** Here the gospel of Jesus Christ shines through the Old Testament text with dazzling force. To save the crew from certain death, one man had to be thrown into the churning depths of God's wrath. But see the difference: Jonah was thrown into the sea for his *own* sin; Jesus Christ

went willingly into the storm of God's righteous judgement on the cross for *our* sin. When Jesus laid down his life, the storm of God's wrath against us was stilled for ever, so that we can have peace with God.

4. **God's grace triumphs even through our stumbling.** Jonah ran because he didn't want pagans to repent. And what happens? Through his very flight, God saves a whole ship full of pagan sailors! God's plan of salvation cannot be stopped by the small faith of his servants.

Living It Out

How often do our lives look exactly like verse 13? Deep in our hearts we know the cause of the unrest inside us. We know which sin must be confessed, which idol must go overboard, or which matter must be put right before the Lord. But instead of bowing and surrendering, **we grip the oars and start digging harder**. We think that if we just work harder, plan better or get the situation under control with our own understanding, we will reach "dry land" again. But the harder we row against God's Spirit, the higher the waves become. True rest only comes when we lay down the oars and submit to his will.

Be on your guard, too, against Jonah's pious fatalism in verse 12. It is possible to admit your guilt freely ("*I know that it is on my account*") without truly repenting. Sometimes we would rather choose self-pity and an emotional "jump overboard" – giving up and writing ourselves off as hopeless – because we are still too proud simply to get on our knees and obey.

Finally, this passage invites us into deep worship. When the sailors saw the raging sea fall still in an instant before the face of the Lord, they were filled with holy awe and offered a sacrifice. When did you last stop at the cross of Christ and realise that the great storm of judgement that should have swallowed you has been completely stilled, because Jesus was thrown into the deep in your place? Let that realisation move you today from mere religious routine to true, grateful worship.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where am I "digging" with my own oars right now?** In what situation am I trying to force a solution through sheer human control and my own strength, when the Lord is really only asking me to surrender?
- **Do I sometimes choose self-reproach over obedience?** Do I tend, like Jonah, to slip into passive guilt ("*It's all my fault, just leave me*") instead of actually turning back to God and putting right what is wrong?
- **What needs to go overboard today?** What specific habit, bitterness or self-will am I still holding on to inside the "ship" of my life, keeping God's peace from ruling there?
- **Does my life reflect the worship of someone who has been rescued?** When I think of how Christ bore the storm of God's judgement in my place, does it stir in me the same deep awe and willingness to give as it did in the sailors in verse 16?

Prayer

Lord, sovereign Ruler of wind and waves, today I lay my oars down at your feet. I confess that, like the sailors, I so often try to dig my way through the storm in my own strength. Even when I know what you are asking of me, I cling to my own plans and try to steer my life to dry land on my own terms. Forgive me for my pride and my stubborn self-reliance.

Lord Jesus, my heart overflows with gratitude today, because you are the true and greater Jonah. Where I deserved to be thrown into the churning waters of judgement for my own rebellion, you willingly took the storm of God's wrath upon yourself on the cross. Thank you for dying so that the sea around me could be still and I could have eternal peace with the Father.

Give me grace today to throw overboard, without holding back, whatever displeases you. Fill my heart afresh with that "great fear" – a holy, overwhelming awe of who you are. Let my life today be a living offering of thanks, to the honour of your wonderful name. Amen.

DAY 4

The Abyss and the Great Fish God Appointed

SCRIPTURE
Jonah 2:1–7

[1] But the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah. And Jonah was
in the belly of the fish three days and three nights. (*English Bibles*: 1:17)
[2] Then Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from the belly of the fish [3] and
said:

I called out of my distress to the LORD,
and he answered me;
from the belly of the grave I cried for help –
you heard my voice.
[4] You had thrown me into the deep,
into the heart of the seas,
and the current surrounded me;
all your breakers and your waves
passed over me.
[5] And I – I said, "I am driven away
from before your eyes.
Yet I will look again
towards your holy temple."
[6] Waters closed around me up to my throat,
the deep surrounded me,
seaweed was wrapped around my head.
[7] To the roots of the mountains I went down;
the earth – its bars closed behind me for ever.
But you brought my life up from the pit,
LORD my God.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 1 the sailors hurled Jonah overboard, and the storm stopped at once. For the men on deck, a holy calm fell; for Jonah, the terrible silence of the deep sea began. As he sinks deeper and deeper into the dark waters of the Mediterranean, with seaweed wrapping around his head like a shroud, his death seems certain.

Then Jonah 2:1 breaks in with an unexpected turn (Hebrew numbering; English Bibles 1:17–2:6 for today's passage): "**But the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah.**"

As literature, something fascinating happens here. Chapter 1 was fast, dramatic prose; chapter 2 switches to **Hebrew poetry** in the form of a classic psalm of thanksgiving. Jonah's prayer weaves together countless phrases and images from the Psalms (compare especially Psalms 18, 30, 42, 69 and 120). As a prophet in Israel, Jonah had been steeped since childhood in the prayer language of the temple. When the air ran out of his lungs and all his clever plans fell apart, it was the word of God he had memorised that rose to the surface in his darkest hour.

We also need to correct a common misunderstanding about the great fish. We often think of the fish as God's **punishment** for Jonah. In fact, drowning in the sea was the punishment; the fish was God's **lifeboat**! Admittedly a dark, cramped and uncomfortable lifeboat – but the place where God preserved Jonah's life and softened his heart again.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew poetry of these verses is rich in wordplay and theological nuance:

- **"Appointed" (*wayman*, from the root *manah* – מָנָה):** This key word means "to assign", "to prepare" or "to allot precisely". It appears four times in the book: God *appoints* the great fish (2:1), he *appoints* the leafy

plant (4:6), he *appoints* the worm (4:7), and he *appoints* the scorching east wind (4:8). The narrator is showing us that the great fish didn't just happen to swim by; the Creator assigned this creature to the exact second and place to catch his servant.

- **"Great fish" (*dag gadol* – דָּג גָּדוֹל):** The Hebrew text names no particular species (such as a whale or a shark); it simply calls it a "great fish". The emphasis is not on marine biology but on the surprising sovereignty of God, who uses even the dreaded monsters of the deep as his obedient servants.
- **"The belly of the grave" (*beten sheol* – בֶּטֶן שְׁאוֹל):** Verse 2 says Jonah prayed from the "belly" (*me'ei*) of the fish, and in verse 3 he calls it the "belly" (*beten*) of the grave (*Sheol*). For the ancient Israelite, the deep (*tehom*, v. 6) and Sheol, the realm of the dead, belonged closely together as the sphere of chaos and death. The belly of the fish feels like a living grave – but by God's grace that grave becomes a womb from which Jonah will be born again.
- **"I went down ... you brought up" (*yaradti ... watta'al* – יָרַדְתִּי ... וַתַּעַל):** ***In verse 7 the familiar yarad ("go down") motif from chapter 1 reaches its lowest point. Jonah went down to Joppa, down into the ship, down into its innermost part – and now he confesses: "To the roots of the mountains I went down (yaradti)." He literally cannot sink any lower; the "bars" of the earth have closed behind him. And there, at the very bottom, for the first time the direction turns for Jonah:*** **"But you*** brought **my life*** *up** from the pit (watta'al)!" *The same verb* (alah*) was used in 1:2 of Nineveh's evil that had "come up" before God.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Recognising God's hand behind our crises.** Look at verse 4: *"You had thrown me into the deep."* Outwardly, it was the sailors' hands that hurled Jonah over the side (1:15). But in the deep, Jonah gains spiritual clarity: he looks past people and circumstances and sees that it was **God**

who was dealing with him. True spiritual restoration begins the day we stop blaming people or "bad luck" and acknowledge that the Lord himself is shaping our lives through his discipline.

2. **Faith that breaks through despair.** Verse 5 contains one of the most honest tensions in Scripture: "*I am driven away from before your eyes*. **Yet** *I will look again towards your holy temple*." Jonah feels rejected and far from God, yet in the middle of his inner darkness his faith clings to God's covenant promise (see Solomon's prayer in 1 Kings 8:38–40 about praying towards the temple). Faith is not the absence of despair; it is the "*yet*" that refuses to stop looking to God's throne of grace.
3. **The "sign of Jonah" – Christ in the depths.** In Matthew 12:40 Jesus himself links this text directly to his own death and resurrection: "*For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the sea monster, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth*." "Three days and three nights" signals that someone was truly and fully in the grip of death. Jesus Christ did not just go as far as the gates of death; he went all the way down into the grave, broke open the bars of death from the inside, and rose on the third day, so that no pit can ever hold us captive again.

Living It Out

We all know times when life feels like the belly of the fish – a dark, cramped, claustrophobic season when all our plans have been jolted to a halt and we can see no way out. Perhaps you are there because of your own wrong choices and disobedience, just like Jonah. You thought you were running to freedom in Tarshish, and you ended up with "seaweed wrapped around your head", trapped in the consequences of your own actions.

Here is the comfort of Jonah 2: **the place that feels like a grave is often God's gracious means of rescue.** If God had not appointed the fish to stop Jonah's flight once and for all and make him still in the darkness, Jonah

would have perished on the sea floor. Sometimes the Lord uses a season of forced standstill, failure or limitation to save us from a much greater spiritual drowning. In the noise of the world Jonah would not pray; in the pitch-dark inside of the fish he starts talking again to "the LORD *his* God".

And don't wait until you feel "worthy" before you cry out. Jonah didn't wait until he was back on the dry shore with his life in order; he prayed *from the belly of the fish*, while he still smelled of stomach acid and seaweed! Even when your emotions scream at you, *"I am driven away; it's too late for me"*, God's Spirit gives you courage today to speak that small word of faith: **"Yet ..."** *Yet* I will lift my eyes to the cross of Christ. No abyss is so deep that the pierced hands of Jesus cannot bring you up out of it.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **How do I see the "great fish" in my life?** Is there a hard limitation, disappointment or standstill in my life that I see as punishment, when the Lord has actually appointed it to save me from a more dangerous road and bring me back to prayer?
- **Have I learned to see God's hand behind my circumstances?** Can I, like Jonah in verse 4, stop simply complaining about the "sailors" (other people) and acknowledge that the Lord himself is at work on my heart?
- **What word am I carrying inside me for dark days?** When Jonah was in total darkness and could read no scroll, he prayed the Psalms from memory. Am I building up a treasury of Scripture in my heart that will carry me when the lights go out?
- **Where do I need a "yet" today?** In what area of my life do I feel hopeless or far from God, where I need to declare in faith: *"Yet I will hope in your grace again"*?

Prayer

LORD *my God, you reign even in the deepest, darkest waters. Out of my own distress I call to you today. Thank you that there is no place in creation – no abyss, no failure and no darkness – where my voice is beyond the reach of your ears.*

I confess that I often only really stop and begin to pray in earnest when I have hit the very bottom and all my own plans have collapsed around me. Thank you for the "great fish" you appoint on my path – those strange, uncomfortable interventions of your grace that keep me from drowning in my own self-will. Even when your discipline rests heavily on me and your waves pass over me, I acknowledge today that your hand is holding me.

When my guilt and my fear whisper that I am driven away from before your eyes, give me faith to cling to your promises and say, "Yet I will look again towards your throne of grace!" Thank you, Lord Jesus, that you went down for me into the deepest realm of death and broke the bars of the grave for ever. Bring my life up today out of the pit of discouragement, and renew my spirit in your presence. Amen.

DAY 5

Prayer from the Darkness: Salvation Belongs to the LORD

SCRIPTURE
Jonah 2:8–11

8 When my soul was fainting within me,
I remembered the LORD,
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
9 Those who cling to worthless idols
abandon their faithful love.
10 But I, with a voice of thanksgiving,
will sacrifice to you;
what I have vowed I will pay.
Salvation belongs to the LORD!

11 Then the LORD spoke to the fish, and it vomited Jonah out onto the dry land.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we reach the climax and close of Jonah's psalm from the depths (Hebrew numbering; English Bibles 2:7–10) – and with it the end of the book's first great act (chapters 1 and 2). In the previous verses Jonah described how he went down to the roots of the mountains, where the bars of the earth closed behind him for ever. Now verses 8 to 10 show us what happened in the inner room of his heart at the very moment his last human strength gave way.

Literarily, the text moves here from an anguished lament to a triumphant **confession of faith and song of thanksgiving**, before verse 11 abruptly returns to narrative. In ancient Israel's worship, someone whom God had rescued from mortal danger went to the temple in Jerusalem to bring a thank offering and pay his vows before the congregation, while telling of God's deliverance (see Psalm 116:17–19). Jonah is miles away from Jerusalem – trapped in the belly of a sea creature – yet his prayer overcomes every geographical and physical barrier and reaches God's holy temple directly.

Notice, too, the subtle irony at the end of the chapter. Jonah closes his lofty, poetic prayer with the mighty cry, "*Salvation belongs to the* LORD*!*" – and the very next moment he is unceremoniously vomited out by a fish onto the dry land! It is a striking reminder: God's salvation is glorious, but it often strips us of our own dignity and pride so that we can be useful in his service again.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text of these four verses contains some of the richest theological expressions in the whole Old Testament:

- "**When my soul was fainting within me**" (***behit'attef alai nafshi*** – **בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי נַפְשִׁי**)**:** The verb *ataf* means "to wrap", "to enfold in a garment", or "to faint from exhaustion". Just as the seaweed was physically wrapped around his head (v. 6), darkness and the terror of death wrapped themselves like a suffocating blanket around his very breath of life (*nefesh*), until he was on the point of losing consciousness.
- "**Worthless idols**" (***havlei-shav*** – **הַבְלֵי־שָׁוְא**)**:** This sharp expression also appears in Psalm 31:6 (Hebrew 31:7). The word *hevel* (familiar from Ecclesiastes as "vanity" or "vapour") is joined here to *shav* – "emptiness", "deceit", "worthlessness". Literally it means "**empty vapours**" or "**deceptive smoke**". Jonah is probably thinking back to the sailors, who at

first each cried out to his own god. But at the same time he realises that his own self-willed plans and his flight to Tarshish were nothing but a handful of smoke.

- **"Faithful love" (*chesed* – חֶסֶד):** One of the crown jewels of the Hebrew Bible. *Chesed* describes God's unshakeable covenant love, his loyal faithfulness and undeserved kindness that never gives up on his people. Verse 9 literally says, *"Those who cling to empty vapours abandon their chesed."* In other words: when you chase after idols or your own way, you turn your back on the only Source of true, steadfast love available to you.
- **"Salvation belongs to the LORD!" (*yeshu'atah la-YHWH* – יְשׁוּעָתָה לַיהוָה):** The word for "salvation", "deliverance" or "rescue" is *yeshu'ah* – the very root from which the name **Yeshua (Jesus)** comes ("the LORD is salvation"). In an intensified, poetic form, Jonah declares here the core message of all Scripture: salvation is never a human achievement or merit; from beginning to end it belongs to the Lord alone.
- **"Vomited out" (*wayyaqe* – וַיָּקֵא):** The verb *qo* literally means "to throw up". Just as the land of Canaan "vomited out" its inhabitants because of their uncleanness (Leviticus 18:25), even the fish could finally no longer keep this stubborn prophet down – but at God's command he lands alive and unharmed on the dry land!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Spiritual remembering as the turning point of despair.** Jonah says in verse 8, *"When my soul was fainting within me, I remembered the* LORD." In biblical thinking, "to remember" (*zakhar*) is far more than a memory exercise. It means tearing your focus away from your overwhelming problem and deliberately anchoring your heart in who God is. Our prayers don't need to be long or impressive to break through the waters into God's holy temple.

2. **The tragic exchange of idolatry.** Verse 9 sums up the folly of all sin in a single sentence. Every time we trust in an "empty vapour" – whether our own control, money, human approval or bitterness – we give up the experience of God's *chesed*, his loving nearness. Sin never delivers what it promises; it only steals the grace we could already have enjoyed in God.
3. **Praise in the dark, before the outcome.** It is crucial to notice *where* Jonah was when he prayed verse 10. When he cried, "*But I, with a voice of thanksgiving, will sacrifice to you … Salvation belongs to the* LORD*!*", he was not yet lying on a sunny beach. He was still in the pitch-dark, cramped belly of the fish! True faith does not wait for circumstances to change before it starts thanking God. It praises God in the dark because it trusts his character.
4. **The sovereign authority of God's word.** Chapter 1 began with the word of the LORD coming to Jonah (1:1) – and Jonah refused to listen. Chapter 2 ends with the LORD speaking to the fish (2:11) – and creation obeys immediately. When God's gracious purpose in our dark season has been fulfilled, he speaks just one word, and the doors of our prison swing open.

Living It Out

Jonah's insight in verse 9 hits our modern lives right between the eyes: "*Those who cling to worthless idols abandon their faithful love.*" We may not bow down to images of wood or stone today, but our hearts are experts at manufacturing modern "empty vapours" (*havlei-shav*). What smoke are you chasing at the moment? Perhaps it is the compulsion always to be in control, the pursuit of success and recognition, clinging to grudges because they give you a false sense of power, or seeking comfort in earthly distractions. When life's storms blow up, none of these things can carry you. They vanish like mist before the sun and leave you empty, robbed of the peace and the *chesed* of the Lord.

This closing passage also teaches us the secret of **thankful surrender in the middle of our crises**. We so badly want to bargain with God: *"Lord, first spit me out onto dry land, first solve my problem – and then I'll praise you joyfully again and keep my promises."* But the breakthrough in Jonah's life came when, still inside the fish, he decided to turn his lament into a song of praise. When Jonah stopped fighting for his own rights and wholeheartedly confessed that salvation belongs to the Lord alone, the command for his release went out.

In the end Jonah lands on dry ground again – probably pale, soaked and stripped of all his former arrogance, but **alive and with a second chance**. No matter how far you have run, or how long you have been trapped in the dark consequences of your own choices: when the Lord sets you down on the shore of his grace, your story is not over. He rescues you from the depths so that he can send you out again with his message of life – and tomorrow we will see exactly that happen to Jonah.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What "empty vapours" are robbing me of God's *chesed* right now?** In what temporary things, human securities or self-willed plans am I placing my trust, so that I miss out on God's nearness and peace?
- **Where do my thoughts go when my soul is fainting within me?** Is my first reflex in times of exhaustion to sink deeper into self-pity and panic – or, like Jonah, deliberately to "remember the LORD"?
- **Can I praise God today, before my circumstances change?** What would it take for me today – perhaps still in the middle of an unresolved situation – to declare with a voice of thanksgiving, *"Salvation belongs to the* LORD"?
- **What am I doing with the "dry land" of my second chances?** When I look back on times the Lord rescued me from a crisis, did I keep my promises to him – or did I quickly forget his goodness again?

Prayer

Lord my God, my Redeemer and the Source of all faithful love, I bow before you today in deep wonder. Thank you that through Jonah 1 and 2 you have opened my eyes to see how futile my own escapes are, and how unfathomably deep your grace is.

I confess with shame how easily I let myself be lured by the "empty vapours" of this world – how often I chase my own comfort, my own control and my own pride, and in doing so turn my back on your precious covenant love. Forgive me for every idol in my heart that tries to take your place. When my soul is fainting within me and my strength runs out, turn my thoughts straight back to your holy temple.

I don't want to wait until every storm has passed and every dark season has cleared before I praise you. Right here, where I am today, I lift my voice in thanksgiving and declare from the depths of my heart: Salvation belongs to the LORD*! Thank you for Jesus Christ, our true Yeshua, who rescued us from the deepest pit. Speak your liberating word over my life, set my feet on solid ground again, and make me ready to go with new obedience wherever you send me. Amen.*

DAY 6

The God of Second Chances and the Cry in Nineveh

SCRIPTURE

Jonah 3:1–4

1 The word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time: 2 "Get up, go to
Nineveh, the great city, and cry out to it the message that I am telling
you." 3 So Jonah got up and went to Nineveh, as the LORD had said. Now
Nineveh was a great city – great even before God – a three days' journey
across. 4 Jonah began to go into the city, one day's journey, and he cried
out and said, "Forty more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!"

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we saw the fish vomit Jonah out onto the dry land. Today the book's second great act begins – and chapter 3 opens with a breathtaking literary mirror image of chapter 1. The narrator uses almost word for word the same opening formula as in Jonah 1:1–2. After the depths, God, as it were, presses the "reset button" on Jonah's life and ministry. Where in chapter 1 Jonah got up to *flee*, in chapter 3 he gets up to *go*.

The journey from the Mediterranean coast to Nineveh – on the east bank of the Tigris, opposite present-day Mosul in northern Iraq – was a gruelling trek of some 800 to 900 kilometres through mountain passes and dry plains. It would have cost Jonah almost a month of walking under the burning sun – a month in which every step tested his new obedience.

Historically, Jonah lived in the first half of the eighth century BC (about 780–750 BC). Assyrian chronicles – the so-called *Eponym Canon* – shed fascinating light on why Nineveh might have been so receptive to a message of judgement at precisely this time. Under the Assyrian king Ashur-dan

III, the empire went through a series of traumatic crises: internal revolts, famine, two devastating plagues (in 765 and 759 BC), and a total solar eclipse on 15 June 763 BC. In the ancient Mesopotamian worldview, such disasters and cosmic signs were taken as proof that the gods were angry. So when this strange prophet from Israel walked through the city gates – perhaps still with skin and hair bleached by the fish's stomach acid – God had already prepared the ground in Nineveh.

What does verse 3 mean when it says Nineveh was **"a three days' journey across"**? In the idiom of the ancient Near East it can refer to one of two things (or both): first, to the greater metropolitan district of Nineveh and its surrounding satellite towns (see Genesis 10:11–12), which had a circumference of some 90 kilometres; or second, to the diplomatic protocol of the time, by which an official envoy took three days to visit a great city: day one for arrival and reception, day two for the official proclamation in the city centre, and day three for departure.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

Every word in these four verses carries special theological weight in the Hebrew text:

- **"A second time" (*shenit* – שֵׁנִית):** This simple word holds an ocean of grace. God could have left Jonah on that beach as a disqualified servant and chosen another prophet. But the word of the LORD comes *shenit* – a second time. God's calling rests on his faithfulness, not on our failure.
- **"The message that I am telling you" (*et-ha-qeri'ah asher anokhi dover eleikha* – אֶת־הַקְּרִיאָה אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי דֹּבֵר אֵלֶיךָ):** Notice the subtle change between God's command in 1:2 and 3:2. In 1:2 God said, *"cry out against it"* (*qera aleha*). Now he says, *"cry out to it the message"* (*qera eleha*) – literally, "cry out to her the cry that I am speaking to you". The verb *dover* is a participle, in the present tense. God does not hand Jonah the whole sermon in advance at Joppa; Jonah has to set out in dependence and hear, step by step, what the Lord gives him to say.

- **"A great city – great even before God" (*ir-gedolah le-Elohim* – עִיר־גְּדוֹלָה לֵאלֹהִים):** Many translations render this "an exceedingly great city". But the Hebrew literally says "**a great city to God**" (or "before God"), and our translation deliberately keeps that. It can be read as a Hebrew superlative, but the deeper meaning lies on the surface: to Jonah, Nineveh was a despised enemy city; to God, it was a city of immeasurable worth.
- **"Forty more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!" (*od arba'im yom we-Nineveh nehpakhet* – עוֹד אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם וְנִינְוֵה נֶהְפָּכֶת):** In Hebrew, Jonah's entire sermon is just **five words**! But the last word – *nehpakhet*, from the root *hafakh* (הָפַךְ) – is a masterpiece of divine double meaning. On the one hand, *hafakh* means "**to overturn**", that is, "**to destroy**" – the very word used for the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah in Genesis 19:25. On the other hand, *hafakh* also means "**to transform completely**", "**to turn around for the good**" – as when Saul is turned into another man (1 Samuel 10:6), or mourning is turned into dancing (Psalm 30:11; Hebrew 30:12). English has no single word that carries both senses; we translate "overturned", but keep the second meaning in mind as you read on. Jonah thinks he is announcing only destruction. But in God's mouth the same word already carries the promise: *in forty days Nineveh will be turned upside down – either by judgement or by repentance!*

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The God of restoration and second chances.** Failure in the past does not mean disqualification for the future. Just as the risen Christ would later restore Peter on a beach beside the Sea of Galilee after his denial (John 21), God restores his runaway prophet on the shore of the Mediterranean and gives him back his commission.
2. **God does not lower his standard to suit us.** When the word comes to Jonah a second time, God does not give him an easier assignment. He doesn't send him to a safe village in Galilee; the assignment is still

Nineveh. God's grace rescues us from the depths – but it always brings us back to the exact point where we last disobeyed.

3. **Faithfulness to the message.** A true messenger of God does not invent his own message to win over his audience; he speaks only what God commands. In the Bible, the number **forty** (like the 40 days of the flood or the 40 years in the wilderness) often marks a time of testing and of grace held open. Even in a message of judgement, a forty-day period is evidence of God's patience, leaving room for repentance.
4. **The power is in the Word, not the preacher.** Jonah preaches the shortest and least friendly sermon in the Bible – five Hebrew words, without a single invitation to grace, without music and without clever rhetoric. And yet these five words will spark the greatest city-wide repentance of the ancient world. It proves that spiritual awakening is the work of God's Spirit and Word, not of human eloquence.

Living It Out

How many of us walk around today with the paralysing feeling that we have forfeited our chance with the Lord? You look back on a season when you ran to your own "Tarshish". And even though you know the Lord has forgiven you and brought you up from the depths, you feel like a second-hand believer who should just sit on the sidelines. Jonah 3:1 breaks through that lie with liberating words: "*The word of the* LORD *came to Jonah a second time*." The scars of your past do not disqualify you. On the contrary, the man who comes out of the belly of the fish carries an authority and a testimony he never had before!

But notice that a second chance always calls for **new obedience**. When God spoke again, Jonah didn't sit down and argue again; he got up and took on the long, dusty road to Nineveh. Where is the Lord calling you back today – to the very thing you once ran away from?

Perhaps the task in front of you feels like a city of "three days' journey" – overwhelmingly big, intimidating, impossible to get through. Look at verse 4: Jonah began by going in **one day's journey**. You don't have to move the whole mountain today. Obedience begins by tackling the first day's journey today and faithfully speaking the words the Lord lays on your heart. And remember: you are not responsible for how people respond. Your task is simply to deliver honestly the five words God gives you, and to leave the "overturning" (*hafakh*) of human hearts to him.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Do I really believe that God is a God of second chances – for me?** Do I let guilt over yesterday's escapes paralyse me today, or am I ready to accept his renewed calling on my life?
- **Have I gone back to my "point of disobedience"?** What original assignment from the Lord is still waiting for my obedience, now that he has rescued me from a crisis?
- **Do I see the world around me as God sees it?** Do I see the difficult, broken people and places around me merely as a threat – or do I see that they are "great even before God" (*le-Elohim*)?
- **What is my "one day's journey" for today?** What first, concrete step of obedience can I take today in something that looks to me like an impossible "three-day challenge"?

Prayer

> *Lord, God of second chances, my heart bows before you today in deep gratitude. Thank you that your Word does not fall silent when I stumble and fail, but that in your incomprehensible grace you speak to your children "a second time". Thank you that you don't leave me on the beach of my past, but pick me up, wash me clean and make me useful in your kingdom again.*

Lord, I confess that I often feel intimidated by the size of the challenges and the hardness of the world you send me into. When I look at my own "Nineveh", it seems too big and too dangerous. But today I choose to look no longer at my own weakness, but at the power of your Word.

Give me the grace to get up and walk the first day's journey of obedience. Teach me to listen to your voice in daily dependence and to speak only what you command – without fear and without compromise. I trust you that your Word still has the power today to turn completely around what has been destroyed, for your glory. Amen.

DAY 7

From the Throne to the Dust: Nineveh's Repentance and God's Grace

SCRIPTURE

Jonah 3:5–10

5 And the people of Nineveh believed God. They called a fast and put on
sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least. 6 When the word
reached the king of Nineveh, he got up from his throne, took off his
royal robe, covered himself with sackcloth, and sat in the ashes. 7 And
he had it cried out in Nineveh and said: "By decree of the king and his
great men: let neither man nor beast, herd nor flock taste anything; let
them not graze, and let them not drink water. 8 Let man and beast be
covered with sackcloth, and let them call out to God with all their
strength. Let each one turn from his evil way and from the violence that
is in his hands. 9 Who knows? God may turn and relent; he may turn
from his burning anger, so that we do not perish." 10 And God saw what
they did, that they turned from their evil way. And God relented of the
evil that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

We often think the greatest miracle in the book of Jonah is the great fish that swallows a man and three days later vomits him out alive. But spiritually speaking, the miracle of Jonah 3:5–10 is far greater: an entire violent, pagan world city comes to deep repentance after a single, reluctant sermon of five Hebrew words!

Watch how this spiritual awakening unfolds. It doesn't start at the top, in the palace, but **down at street level** (v. 5). The ordinary citizens of Nineveh – "from the greatest of them to the least", rich and poor, old and young – hear Jonah's words, immediately believe God, call a fast and put

on sackcloth (coarsely woven goat-hair cloth that scratched the skin and signified the deepest grief). Only then does the wave of repentance reach the palace (v. 6).

Given Assyrian culture, the reaction of the king of Nineveh is almost unthinkable. Assyrian monarchs saw themselves as the invincible representatives of the gods on earth; their palace walls were decorated with reliefs that displayed their arrogance and ruthless power. Yet when this king hears God's word of judgement, he does four radical things:

1. He **gets up from his throne** (he lays aside his majesty and authority).
2. He **takes off his royal robe** (he strips himself of his outward glory and dignity).
3. He **covers himself with sackcloth** (he identifies himself with the guilt of his people).
4. He **sits in the ashes** (the ultimate symbol of human nothingness and ruin).

Even the cattle and beasts of burden are included in the fast and the sackcloth (vv. 7–8). To modern ears this sounds strange, but it was a documented custom in the ancient Near East and the Persian world: the Greek historian Herodotus describes similar mourning practices among the Persians, and we read of it in the apocryphal book of Judith (Judith 4:10). The aim was to bring the whole economy and the entire created order to a standstill; even the lowing of hungry, thirsty cattle was to rise to heaven as a cry for help alongside the people's prayers.

Literarily, the king's words in verse 9 are a beautiful mirror image of the pagan ship's captain's words in 1:6. The captain said, "*Perhaps that god will give a thought to us, and we will not perish.*" The king says, "*Who knows? God may turn and relent … so that we do not perish.*" While Israel and Jonah take their covenant privileges for granted, these pagan leaders show us what true, humble pleading before the living God looks like.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text of these six verses lays bare the heart of biblical repentance and of God's grace:

- **"And the people of Nineveh believed God" (*wayya'aminu anshei Nineveh be-Elohim* – וַיַּאֲמִינוּ אַנְשֵׁי נִינְוֵה בֵּאלֹהִים):** The verb *aman* (אָמַן – the source of our word "Amen") means to rest your full weight on something, to accept someone as completely reliable and true. It is exactly the same form used of Abraham in **Genesis 15:6** ("*And he believed the* LORD"). They didn't just believe Jonah; they believed **God**!
- **"Violence" (*chamas* – חָמָס):** In verse 8 the king commands everyone to turn from "*the violence that is in his hands*". The word *chamas* refers to brutal bloodshed, oppression and merciless exploitation – the very word Genesis 6:11 uses to describe the corruption of the world before the flood. Nineveh's repentance was not some vague, emotional regret; they named their specific national wickedness and let it go.
- **"Turn" (*shuv* – שׁוּב):** This verb is the hinge of chapter 3 and occurs four times in verses 8 to 10. It means to make a 180-degree turn and walk in the opposite direction. Look at the chain reaction: the people **turn** from their evil way (vv. 8, 10), and therefore God **turns** from his burning anger (v. 9).
- **"Relented" (*wayyinnachem*, from the root *nacham* – נָחַם):** This deep, emotionally charged word means to sigh deeply, to be moved with compassion, or to hold back from an intended punishment. It certainly does not mean that God had made a mistake or changes his mind on a whim as humans do. Because God's character is unchangeably righteous *and* gracious, his dealings with a city must change when that city turns from its sin (see Jeremiah 18:7–8). Notice, too: he relents of "the evil" (*ha-ra'ah*) he had said he would do – the same word as their "evil" way. Tomorrow we will see this word suddenly come back on Jonah himself in 4:1.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True repentance begins with faith and becomes visible in deeds.** Notice the order in the text: in verse 5 they **believe** God; in verses 6–8 they **humble** themselves and **call out** to God; and in verse 10 we read, *"And God saw **what they did** (literally, "their works"), that they turned from their evil way."* God is not impressed by mere religious ritual, tears, or sackcloth and ashes in themselves (see Isaiah 58:5–6). He looks at our hands: have we really let go of the *chamas* – the injustice and sin we were clinging to?

2. **Grace is never a demand, but a sovereign gift.** The king's words in verse 9 (*"Who knows? God may turn ..."*) show deep theological insight. He doesn't think his fasting and sackcloth can twist God's arm or "buy" forgiveness. He understands that they deserve judgement and can only throw themselves on God's undeserved mercy.

3. **Nineveh's "overturning" fulfils Jonah's prophecy at a higher level.** Do you remember the double-edged Hebrew word *nehpakhet* ("overturned") in Jonah's sermon (3:4)? Nineveh was indeed completely "overturned" within forty days – not by fire and brimstone like Sodom, but by the renewing grace of God! God likes best to destroy his enemies by turning them into his friends.

4. **Jesus' warning about Nineveh.** In Matthew 12:41 Jesus says, *"The men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgement with this generation and condemn it, for they repented at the preaching of Jonah – and look, something greater than Jonah is here!"* Nineveh repented on the strength of five curt words from a reluctant prophet – without a Bible, without the cross and the resurrection. How much greater is our responsibility, who have the full revelation of God's love in Jesus Christ!

Living It Out

Nineveh's response holds up a sharp mirror to our own hearts today. We live at a time when we are often quick to write off people, groups or even whole cultures as "beyond the reach" of God's grace. We look at the hardness, the secularism or the wickedness of our society and think it is pointless to pray or to bear witness. But if God could bring the most bloodthirsty city of the ancient world to its knees in a single day, then **no one** in your life is too far gone for his Spirit to reach.

Second, the king of Nineveh shows us what true personal humbling looks like. When the Word of the Lord confronts us about our own sin, our natural reflex is to stay seated on our "throne" and pull our "royal robe" of excuses, self-justification and pride more tightly around us. True repentance asks us to climb down from the throne of our own ego, take off our masks, and bow in the dust before God without excuses.

Finally, verse 8 challenges us to be specific in our confession. The king asks each person to look at "*the violence that is in his hands*". It is easy to pray in general terms: "*Lord, forgive all my sins*." It is much harder – but infinitely more freeing – to open your hands before the Lord and let go of the specific thing you are clinging to: the bitterness you nurse, the dishonesty in your business, the sharp tongue you use to tear others down, or the secret screen habit that pollutes your soul. When God sees that we are truly turning, he meets us every time with his overflowing compassion.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **On what "throne" am I still sitting in my life?** What "royal robe" of pride, reputation or self-justification keeps me from bowing before the Lord truly defenceless and honest?
- **What is in my hands right now?** If the Holy Spirit shines his light on my daily walk today, what specific evil way or habit do I need to name and let go of?

- **Is my repentance visible in what I do?** Can the people around me – my family, my colleagues – see from my actions and behaviour that I have turned to God, or does my faith stay at the level of fine words?
- **Whom have I already written off in my heart?** For what person or situation have I stopped praying because I think they are "too hard" to change – while God may simply be waiting to show his miracle of grace there?

Prayer

Almighty and merciful God, I stand amazed today at the miracle of Nineveh. You are the God who can soften rock-hard hearts in a moment and turn a city full of violence into a place of prayer. Forgive me for my little faith when I look at broken people or dark situations and think your arm is too short to save.

Lord, like the king of Nineveh, I want to step down from my own throne today. I take off my robe of pride, excuses and self-assertion before you. Search my heart and show me what is in my hands that grieves you. I don't want to confess only with my lips or practise an outward form of religion; I want to turn with my whole life from every evil way.

Thank you that I don't have to wonder, "Who knows whether God will be gracious?" – for in Jesus Christ and his death on the cross I have the firm assurance that your arms are wide open to everyone who turns back to you. Wash my hands clean, renew what I do, and let my life be a visible testimony to your transforming grace. Amen.

DAY 8

The Displeased Prophet: When God's Grace Makes Us Angry

SCRIPTURE

Jonah 4:1–4

1 But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil – and his anger burned. 2 He
prayed to the LORD and said, "Please, LORD, is this not what I said while I
was still in my own country? That is why I fled to Tarshish in the first
place. For I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow
to anger and abounding in faithful love, and one who relents over evil.
3 So now, LORD, please take my life from me, for my death is better than
my life." 4 But the LORD said, "Is it right for your anger to burn?"

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

If the book of Jonah ended with chapter 3, Jonah would go down in history as the most successful preacher of the Old Testament. No other prophet – not Isaiah, Jeremiah or Ezekiel – ever saw an entire world city, from king to beggar, bow before the Lord in sackcloth and ashes within a single day. Any preacher would have shouted for joy. But chapter 4 opens with one of the most shocking twists in the whole Bible: **Jonah is furious because his sermon worked!**

Here, in verse 2, the riddle of chapter 1 is finally solved. Why did Jonah run to Tarshish in the first place? We often assume he was afraid the cruel Assyrians would kill him. But Jonah himself confesses the real reason: he wasn't afraid his mission to Nineveh would *fail* – he was terrified it would *succeed*! He knew that if he delivered God's warning, Nineveh might repent. And he knew God well enough to know that God would then forgive them.

Historically, Jonah's anger was rooted in a fiery but twisted patriotism. Jonah's contemporaries, the prophets Hosea and Amos, had already warned that God would use a foreign nation to discipline the northern kingdom of Israel for its refusal to repent (see Hosea 11:5; Amos 5:27). Jonah realised that a spared Nineveh remained a living threat to Israel's future – and indeed, only a few decades later (in 722 BC) Assyria would invade Israel and carry its people away. On top of that, Jonah felt his reputation as a prophet had been destroyed: he had announced that the city would be overturned in forty days, and now its walls were still standing!

Literarily, Jonah's prayer in chapter 4 forms a tragic contrast with his prayer in chapter 2:

- In chapter 2 he prays from the belly of the fish in **gratitude**, because God saved *him* from drowning.
- In chapter 4 he prays outside Nineveh in **anger**, because God saved *others* from destruction.
- In both cases he prefers death to obedience to God's plan (compare 1:12 with 4:3). Jonah is the Old Testament forerunner of the **older brother** in Jesus' parable of the lost son (Luke 15:25–32), who stands outside and refuses to go in to the feast because the father has been gracious to an unworthy sinner.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text exposes the depth of Jonah's spiritual crisis through brilliant wordplay:

- **"A great evil" (*ra'ah gedolah* – רָעָה גְּדוֹלָה):** The narrator plays masterfully with the Hebrew word *ra'ah* ("evil", "wickedness", "disaster"). In 1:2 Nineveh's *ra'ah* (evil) came up before God. In 3:8 Nineveh turns from its evil (*ra'ah*) way, and in 3:10 God relents of the evil (*ra'ah*) he had said he would do to them. And now, in 4:1, we read: "*But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil.*" God's grace, which wipes out Nineveh's evil, is in Jonah's eyes itself "a great evil"!

- **"His anger burned" (*wayyichar lo* – וַיִּחַר לוֹ):** The verb *charah* literally means **"to burn"** or **"to blaze"**. Notice the irony: in 3:9 the king of Nineveh hoped that God would turn *"from his burning anger"* (*charon appo*). The moment God's anger stops burning, Jonah's starts!
- **The creed of Exodus 34:6 (*El-channun we-rachum, erekh appayim we-rav-chesed* – אֵל־חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב־חֶסֶד):** In verse 2 Jonah quotes the most famous and sacred self-revelation of God in the whole Old Testament – the words God gave Moses on Mount Sinai after the sin of the golden calf (Exodus 34:6–7; see also Psalm 103:8 and Joel 2:13):
- *Channun* (gracious – he gives undeserved favour).
- *Rachum* (compassionate – from *rechem*, "womb", pointing to a deep, motherly tenderness and mercy).
- *Erekh appayim* (slow to anger – literally "long of nostrils": someone who takes a deep breath and is very slow to become angry).
- *Rav-chesed* (abounding in faithful love – overflowing in covenant love).

What makes this verse so shocking is that Jonah uses the most beautiful confession of praise in Israel's worship as a **reproach and accusation** against God! - **"Is it right for your anger to burn?" (*ha-heitev charah lakh* – הַהֵיטֵב חָרָה לָךְ):** The LORD does not answer with thunderbolts but with three quiet Hebrew words that literally ask: *"Is it good/right that it burns in you?"* Just as God asked Cain, *"Why has your anger burned?"* (Genesis 4:6 – the same verb *charah*), he uses a diagnostic question to awaken Jonah's own conscience.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The hypocrisy of selective grace.** At the end of chapter 2 Jonah cried out wholeheartedly, *"Salvation belongs to the* LORD*!"* (2:10; Hebrew numbering – English Bibles 2:9). But in chapter 4 we discover that Jonah thinks the Lord's salvation belongs only to *him* and *his* people. We fall

into the same trap when we think we have somehow "earned" God's grace, while other people's sins are too great to be forgiven. But if grace is not also available to Nineveh, it is no longer grace.

2. **Right theology without a changed heart is dangerous.** Jonah could recite Exodus 34:6 flawlessly from memory, but his heart beat with the opposite attitude. It is possible to know Scripture inside out and to know exactly how God works – and still live in bitterness towards his kingdom, because you put your own agenda above his.
3. **The idol of our own honour and security.** Jonah's death wish in verse 3 ("*my death is better than my life*") reveals what was really driving him. When he saw that God's plan did not fit his political expectations and his standing as a prophet, his world collapsed. Anything – even good things like love for your people or your ministry – that becomes more important than God's will turns into a destructive idol.
4. **God shows patience to his angry prophet.** How does God respond when Jonah rails at him over his grace? At that very moment God proves that he truly is *erekh appayim* – slow to anger! Instead of rejecting Jonah for his disrespectful outburst, the Lord engages him in conversation like a patient father and counsellor.

Living It Out

It's easy to look at Jonah with disapproval – until we realise how often a little Jonah hides inside us. Have you ever felt something "burn" in you with resentment when God blesses or acquits someone who wronged you? When someone who hurt you, or who by your standards "wasn't punished hard enough", turns to God and prospers, our natural sense of justice experiences it as "a great evil" (*ra'ah gedolah*). For ourselves we would love the God of Exodus 34:6, who covers our faults with the cloak of love – but for our enemies we demand a judge who strikes at once with fire and brimstone.

This passage also challenges how we react when God's ways don't match our expectations. Sometimes we get angry with the Lord – not because he has done anything wrong, but because he refused to act according to *our* script. When our prayers aren't answered the way we prescribed, or when we don't get our way, we easily slip into spiritual melodrama and self-pity like Jonah in verse 3: we want to throw in the towel, lay down our ministry and feel sorry for ourselves.

But listen today to the gentle voice of the Lord, who comes to you in the middle of your frustration, disappointment or resentment with that one searching question: **"Is it right for your anger to burn?"** (*Is it right that it burns in you like this*?) God is not afraid of your raw, honest prayers – Jonah at least brought his anger to the Lord in prayer instead of boarding another ship. But when you pour out your complaint before him, be ready for his loving question to turn the mirror back onto your own heart.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Towards whom am I harbouring an "older brother" attitude right now?** Is there someone in my life to whom I refuse, in my heart, to grant forgiveness and restoration, because I feel they must first "pay" for what they did?
- **Where does God's character clash with my preferences?** Do I know God's grace and sovereignty only in my head – or do I also trust him when he chooses to work in ways that threaten my pride or my comfort?
- **How do I react when my plans are thrown into disarray?** Do I tend, like Jonah, to sink into deep discouragement and self-pity when things don't work out the way I thought they should?
- **How will I answer God's question in verse 4 today?** If the Lord asks me today about the specific thing I am bitter, frustrated or angry about – "*Is it right for your anger to burn*?" – what does that reveal about what matters most to me in life?

Prayer

Lord, gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love, I bow before you today with an honest heart. When I look at Jonah's anger, I so often see my own reflection. I confess how quickly I claim your overflowing grace for myself when I am in the depths – and how slow I am to grant that same grace to others who have hurt or disappointed me.

Forgive me for the times something burns in me with resentment because your ways are higher than my ways. Forgive me when I put my own reputation, my own sense of justice and my own expectations above your kingdom. Thank you that you do not answer my spiritual small-mindedness with anger, but in your patience you speak with me and search my heart with your gentle questions.

Heal every grudge and every trace of bitterness in me today. Tear down the selfish walls I try to build around your love. Shape my heart so that I know your character not only with my mind, but love what you love and rejoice over everyone who returns from darkness to your light. In the name of Jesus, who prayed even for his enemies from the cross. Amen.

DAY 9

The Plant, the Worm and the Scorching East Wind

SCRIPTURE
Jonah 4:5–8

5 Jonah went out of the city and sat down east of the city. There he made
himself a shelter and sat under it in the shade, until he could see what
would happen in the city. 6 Then the LORD God appointed a leafy plant
and made it grow up over Jonah, to be shade over his head, to deliver
him from his evil. And Jonah rejoiced over the plant with great joy.
7 But God appointed a worm when dawn came up the next day, and it
struck the plant, so that it withered. 8 When the sun rose, God ap-
pointed a scorching east wind, and the sun struck Jonah's head, so that
he grew faint. He asked that he might die, and said, "My death is better
than my life."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of yesterday's passage the Lord asked Jonah a direct, piercing question: "*Is it right for your anger to burn?*" (4:4). But Jonah gives no answer. Like a sulking child who refuses to talk it through, he turns around, walks out through Nineveh's city gates and climbs the hills east of the city. There he builds himself a simple shelter of branches and sits down like a spectator in a grandstand to see "*what would happen in the city*". In spite of the city's repentance and God's grace, Jonah still secretly hopes that the forty days will run out and that fire from heaven will fall on his enemies after all!

On the dry, treeless plains of Mesopotamia the summer sun could burn mercilessly, with temperatures easily rising above 40 degrees Celsius. Jonah's homemade shelter soon dries out in the heat – and this is where

God switches from a **question** to a **living object lesson**. Just as the prophet Nathan had to tell King David a story about a poor man's lamb so that David could see his own sin (2 Samuel 12), God creates a physical parable around Jonah to break open his hardened heart.

Notice the meaningful change in God's names in these verses. In verse 6 the narrator suddenly uses the compound name **the LORD God** (YHWH *Elohim*) – a rare combination in the Prophets, best known from the creation and fall narratives of Genesis 2 and 3. He is both YHWH (the loving covenant Lord who cares for his child) and *Elohim* (the almighty Creator who rules over nature).

The means God uses in this object lesson were well known in the ancient Near East:

- **The plant (*qiqayon*):** Most scholars identify it as the castor-oil plant (*Ricinus communis*) or a fast-growing gourd. In the fertile soil along the Tigris this plant could shoot up extraordinarily fast, with large, broad leaves giving wonderful, cool shade.
- **The scorching east wind:** This refers to the dreaded *sirocco* (or *sharav*), a searing, dusty desert wind from the eastern plateaus that sucks the moisture out of the air in an instant, makes the heat unbearable, and leaves people and plants parched and fainting within hours.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text of verses 5 to 8 is a literary masterpiece, full of irony and repetition, that lays bare Jonah's spiritual condition:

- **"A shelter" (*sukkah* – סֻכָּה):** The word for the shelter Jonah weaves is *sukkah* – exactly the word for the booths of Israel's Feast of Tabernacles (*Sukkot*). That feast was a yearly reminder of how graciously God had provided for and protected Israel in the wilderness (Leviticus 23:42–43). The irony is striking: Jonah sits under a *sukkah* that reminds him of God's undeserved grace to Israel, while he waits for God to destroy Nineveh without grace!

- **"To deliver him from his evil" (*lehatsil lo mera'ato* – לְהַצִּיל לוֹ מֵרָעָתוֹ):** Here the wordplay on *ra'ah* ("evil", "wickedness", "misery") reaches its climax. The phrase has a deliberate double meaning: on the surface the plant gives shade to relieve Jonah of his physical *discomfort*, but at a deeper level God does it **"to deliver him from his own evil – his bitterness"**. Nineveh has already been saved from its *ra'ah*; now the prophet still needs to be delivered from his own *ra'ah*, his angry, selfish heart! On top of that, *lehatsil* ("to deliver") echoes *tsel* ("shade") – the shade itself is a deliverance.
- **"Jonah rejoiced ... with great joy" (*wayyismach Yonah ... simchah gedolah* – וַיִּשְׂמַח יוֹנָה ... שִׂמְחָה גְדוֹלָה):** Literally: *"And Jonah rejoiced over the plant with great joy."* This is a shocking remark: it is the **first and only time** in the whole book that Jonah is happy! When the sailors turned to God, he wasn't glad. When Nineveh was saved, it was to him *ra'ah gedolah*, "a great evil" (4:1). But when a plant shields his own head from the sun, he suddenly feels *simchah gedolah* – "great joy"!
- **"Appointed" (*wayman* – וַיְמַן):** This key verb appears three times in a row, in verses 6, 7 and 8. In 2:1 (Hebrew numbering; English Bibles 1:17) the LORD *appointed* a **great fish**. Now he *appoints* a **plant** (v. 6), he *appoints* a single **worm** (*tola'at*, v. 7), and he *appoints* a **scorching east wind** (*ruach qadim charishit*, v. 8). Whether it's a huge sea creature in the deep or a tiny worm at dawn, the whole of creation obeys God's command perfectly – only the heart of his prophet still resists.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The idol of personal comfort.** Jonah's emotional see-saw between verse 6 and verse 8 is disturbing. In verse 6 he is ecstatic over a bit of shade; in verse 8 he wants to die because it's hot. When personal ease and comfort become the highest priority in our lives, we become spiritually blind to God's kingdom and emotionally at the mercy of the smallest change in our circumstances.

2. **Our own "shelters" can't protect us.** Jonah first tried to build his own *sukkah* (v. 5), but it wasn't enough against the heat; God had to make the plant grow up to give real shade (v. 6). We constantly try to build our own human shelters and securities to shield ourselves from life, but true refreshment is always a gift of God's grace.
3. **The grace of the worm.** We easily understand that the shade plant was a gift from God, but verse 7 teaches us that the **worm** was just as surely appointed by God. Why does God's worm destroy Jonah's beloved plant? Because Jonah had begun to love the gift more than the Giver, and to value his comfort above human lives. Sometimes the Lord sends a "worm" to make an earthly prop or comfort zone in our lives wither – precisely to shake us awake from our self-centredness.
4. **Jonah on the hill and Christ on the hill.** Look at Jonah sitting on a hill east of Nineveh, seeking his own comfort and hoping for the city's destruction. Then look at Jesus Christ, "greater than Jonah", who centuries later looks out over the city from the Mount of Olives – also east of Jerusalem – and **weeps** because it rejects his peace (Luke 19:41). Where Jonah complained because the sun struck his head, Jesus hung on a cross outside the city gates under the scorching sun and endured the full heat of God's judgement, so that enemies might be saved.

Living It Out

Jonah on the eastern hill is the classic picture of the **critical religious spectator**. How easily we slip into the same posture! Instead of staying inside "Nineveh", teaching the new believers and celebrating God's grace with them, we withdraw to a safe distance. We sit in our comfortable "shelters", look critically at the brokenness of the world or the failings of other believers, and wait with folded arms to see things go wrong.

This passage also exposes our daily priorities. What gives you *"great joy"* (*simchah gedolah*), and what drives you to despair? If we're honest, our emotional life often looks just like Jonah's: we get very excited when our

material affairs run smoothly, when our holiday plans work out or our finances flourish – yet we are hardly moved by the spiritual salvation or eternal destiny of the people around us. And as soon as an unexpected "worm" shows up – a financial setback, a plan that falls through, a comfort that's taken away – and the "east wind" of trial blows against us, our whole mood collapses.

If you are experiencing today that a "plant" in which you found joy and rest has suddenly withered, don't immediately conclude that God has abandoned you. Ask instead: *What does the Lord want to reveal in my heart through this loss*? He never takes away our passing shade to destroy us, but to deliver us from the evil of self-centredness, so that we may know him as our one true refuge.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Have I become a spectator on the hill?** Is there a situation, a church or a group of people from which I have critically withdrawn to sit and judge from a distance, instead of staying involved with compassion?
- **What do my joy and my sorrow reveal about my heart?** When I look at what made me happiest and angriest this past week, was it mainly about my own temporary comfort ("my plant") or about the things that matter for God's kingdom?
- **What "plant" has the Lord recently allowed to wither in my life?** How did I react when a security or comfort zone was taken from me – with bitterness and discouragement, or with an open heart to hear what God wants to teach me?
- **Where do I look for shade when the "scorching east wind" blows?** Do I trust the fragile "shelters" I build with my own hands, or do I take refuge under the wings of the Most High?

Prayer

LORD God, sovereign Creator and loving Father, I bow before you today, aware of how small and self-centred my heart so often is. You see how easily I sit on the sidelines, caught up in my own little world, while you are at work in the eternal salvation of the people around me.

Forgive me, Lord, that I so often find "great joy" in the passing comforts and earthly blessings that make my life easy, while my heart stays cold to the spiritual need of others. Forgive me for the times I become discouraged and rebellious as soon as a worm makes my earthly joys wither and the scorching east wind of trial blows over my life.

Thank you that you love me too much to leave me in my selfish displeasure. Thank you for the plants of grace with which you refresh me – but thank you also for the worms you appoint to take away my false securities, so that I lean on you alone. Deliver me today from my own bitterness and small-mindedness. Teach me to find my deepest joy not in shifting shade, but in Jesus Christ, my Rock and my eternal refuge. Amen.

DAY 10

The Unanswered Question: God's Father-Heart and Our Small-Heartedness

SCRIPTURE
Jonah 4:9–11

9 But God said to Jonah, "Is it right for your anger to burn over the
plant?" He said, "It is right for my anger to burn – to the point of death!"
10 Then the LORD said, "You had pity on the plant, for which you did not
labour and which you did not make grow; it came into being in a night
and perished in a night. 11 And should I not have pity on Nineveh, the
great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand
people who do not know their right hand from their left – and many ani-
mals as well?"

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today, on the last day of our journey, we reach the final three verses of the book of Jonah – one of the most dramatic and unexpected closing scenes in all of world literature. After the worm has destroyed the plant and the scorching east wind has driven Jonah to the edge of sunstroke and exhaustion, God repeats in verse 9 exactly the question he asked in verse 4 – but with two Hebrew words added: *"Is it right for your anger to burn over the plant?"*

Where Jonah walked away in stubborn silence in verse 4, the dam of his frustration now bursts. Without any restraint or reverence he as good as shouts back at heaven: *"It is right for my anger to burn – to the point of death!"* And with that, Jonah walks straight into the loving trap God has

set for him. By admitting that the loss of a mere plant upsets him to the point of death, he gives the Lord the perfect starting point to lay open the deepest lesson of the book.

Literarily, the book of Jonah ends with an **unanswered rhetorical question**. In the whole Old Testament only two books end with a question mark: **Jonah** and **Nahum** – and remarkably, both books are about the city of Nineveh! (In Jonah, God asks who could hold back his grace from a repentant Nineveh; in Nahum 3:19 he asks who could rescue a later, rebellious Nineveh from his just judgement.)

Why doesn't the author tell us what Jonah answered on the hill? Did Jonah finally weep and come to his senses – or did he get up angry and walk away? The silence at the end of verse 11 is a deliberate literary masterstroke: at the last second the camera swings away from Jonah and focuses squarely on **you, the reader**. God's question hangs in the air so that each of us must answer it with our own life.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

The Hebrew text of these final verses pulses with the emotion of God's Creator-heart:

- **"Have pity" (*chus* – חוּס):** This key word in verses 10 and 11 means to look at something with deep compassion and pity, to want to spare it – or (according to some linguists) the eye shedding a tear of mercy. The Lord says to Jonah: *"You had pity (chasta) on the plant … and should I not have pity (achus) on Nineveh?"* Jonah does have compassion in him – but it is aimed at the wrong object.
- **"For which you did not labour and which you did not make grow" (*lo-amalta bo we-lo giddalto* – לֹא־עָמַלְתָּ בּוֹ וְלֹא גִדַּלְתּוֹ):** The verb *amal* refers to heavy, sweat-of-the-brow toil, and *giddel* means to nourish and raise a child with care – literally "to make great", the verb behind *gadol*, "great", which runs through the whole book. Jonah didn't plant the seed, water it or make it grow – and yet he was attached to it. Over

against him stands God as the Creator who formed every inhabitant of Nineveh in the womb, fed them and sustained their breath of life. God has a personal investment in his creation!

- **"It came into being in a night" (*she-bin-laylah hayah* – שֶׁבִּן־לַיְלָה הָיָה):** Literally, the Hebrew calls the plant **"a son of a night"** (*ben-laylah*) – a lovely idiom for something fleeting, temporary and short-lived. How foolish to pledge your soul to "a son of a night" while people created for eternity are perishing all around you!
- **"Who do not know their right hand from their left" (*lo-yada bein-yemino lismolo* – לֹא־יָדַע בֵּין־יְמִינוֹ לִשְׂמֹאלוֹ):** This expression can be understood in two ways: 1. It refers to **little children** who are too young to tell left from right (which would mean the total population of greater Nineveh was over 600,000). 2. It refers to the spiritual and moral blindness of all **120,000 inhabitants** – people who grew up without God's law and grope about spiritually like lost children in the dark.

Either way the point is the same: where Jonah looks at their ignorance with contempt, God looks at it with a father's mercy.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's argument from the lesser to the greater (*qal wachomer*).** In verses 10 and 11 God uses the classic Jewish *qal wachomer* argument ("how much more") that Jesus also used so often in the Gospels (see Matthew 7:11; 12:12). If a sinful, selfish man like Jonah can feel natural pity for a single, soulless plant that is only one night old, **how much more** will the infinite, loving Creator have compassion on hundreds of thousands of people and animals who are the work of his own hands!
2. **Spiritual blindness moves God to mercy.** When Jesus looked at the crowds, he was moved with compassion for them, because they were harassed and scattered like sheep without a shepherd (Matthew 9:36).

God does not excuse Nineveh's sin, but he sees their spiritual helplessness. When they turn to him in repentance, his Father's heart refuses to crush them.

3. **God's care includes his whole creation ("... and many animals as well").** The very last words of the book of Jonah in the original text refer to the **many animals** (*u-vehemah rabbah*). To us it sounds almost like a strange anticlimax, but theologically it is wonderful: God's mercy reaches even the innocent animals that would otherwise perish in judgement on human beings (see Psalm 36:6 – Hebrew 36:7 – "*Man and beast you save*, O LORD", and Psalm 145:9).

4. **The book's very existence is Jonah's confession.** Did Jonah ever learn his lesson? Ask yourself: *Who told the story of Jonah*? Only Jonah himself could have known what happened in the innermost part of the ship, in the belly of the fish, and in the private conversation between him and God on the eastern hill. The fact that we have this mercilessly honest book in our Bibles today – in which the prophet exposes his own pride and small-heartedness without any excuses, so that God alone is glorified – is a strong indication that God's final question broke Jonah's hard heart in the end!

Living It Out

God's final question to Jonah echoes down the centuries into our own living rooms and churches. We live in a world full of "**sons of a night**" – temporary plants to which we pledge our hearts. We shed tears, lose sleep and get upset "to the point of death" over things that won't make the slightest difference in fifty years: a bruised ego, a political argument on social media, a financial gain or loss, our personal comfort, or our own way of doing things. We are experts at caring passionately about leaves that will wither tomorrow, while we shrug our shoulders at people heading without Christ towards an eternity without God.

How do you look today at the "Ninevites" in your life and in our society – the people who "do not know their right hand from their left"? When we look at a world that has lost its moral bearings, that calls good evil and evil good, our first reaction is often just like Jonah's: outrage, anger and a desire that they get what they deserve. But the Spirit of Christ calls us to look at spiritually lost people with God's *chus* – his tears of mercy. They are not enemies to be hated; they are lost creatures of God who need the gospel.

The book of Jonah ends without a full stop, so that today you can go and write the next chapter with your feet and your heart. Will you stay sitting on the hill of your own comfort and bitterness, grieving over a dead plant? Or will you get up, join the Father's heart, and go and share his incomprehensible grace with a broken world?

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Which "sons of a night" are stealing my deepest emotional energy right now?** Which temporary, earthly things am I currently more upset and worried about than the eternal well-being of the people around me?
- **How do I react to the spiritual blindness of our time?** When I see people outside the church living in sin and confusion – people who "do not know their right hand from their left" –, does it stir up proud contempt in me, or Christlike compassion?
- **Have I accepted God's right to be gracious to whomever he wills?** Am I willing to lay down my own small standards of who "deserves" grace, and to rejoice in God's boundless Father-heart?
- **How will I answer the open closing question of Jonah today?** As I look back over this whole ten-day journey through Jonah 1 to 4 – from the flight to Tarshish to the hill east of Nineveh – what one specific change is the Lord asking of me today in my attitude, my prayer life and my obedience?

Prayer

Lord my God, Creator of heaven and earth, at the end of this journey through the book of Jonah I fall silent and humbled at your feet. Your final question lays my heart bare to the bone. With deep repentance I confess how often I am like Jonah – how easily I grieve, complain and grow angry when my own little "plants" of comfort, pride and earthly security are touched, while the need of a lost world leaves me untouched.

Forgive me for being so often caught up in the things that come into being in a night and perish in a night. Break my small-heartedness and heal my spiritual short-sightedness. Thank you that you are the God who cares not only for Israel or for your own people, but whose Father-heart beats for every city, for every lost soul groping in the dark – and even for the animals of the field.

Lord Jesus, thank you that you are the true and perfect Prophet – that you did not sit on a hill waiting for our destruction, but out of love for your enemies died on the cross to save us. Pour your own compassion into my heart today through the Holy Spirit. I no longer want to stay sitting on the hill of my own selfishness. Today I get up to love what you love, to show grace as you have shown grace to me, and to place my life wholly in the service of your kingdom. Salvation belongs to you alone, now and for ever! Amen.

The whole book of Jonah

The complete text of Jonah in the translation used in these devotionals. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew: English Bibles number 2:1 as 1:17 and 2:2–11 as 2:1–10.

Chapter 1

[1] The word of the LORD came to Jonah son of Amittai: [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, the great city, and cry out against it, for their evil has come up before my face." [3] So Jonah got up – to flee to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD. He went down to Joppa and found a ship bound for Tarshish. He paid the fare and went down into it, to go with them to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD.

[4] But the LORD hurled a great wind onto the sea, and there was a great storm on the sea, so that the ship threatened to break apart. [5] The sailors were afraid, and each cried out to his own god. They hurled the cargo that was in the ship into the sea to lighten it for themselves. But Jonah had gone down into the innermost part of the ship, had lain down, and had fallen into a deep sleep. [6] The captain came to him and said to him, "What are you doing asleep? Get up, call out to your god! Perhaps that god will give a thought to us, and we will not perish." [7] Then they said to one another, "Come, let us cast lots, so that we may know on whose account this evil has come upon us." So they cast lots, and the lot fell on Jonah. [8] Then they said to him, "Tell us, please, on whose account this evil has come upon us! What is your work, and where do you come from? What is your country, and from what people are you?" [9] He said to them, "A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of heaven, I fear – he who made the sea and the dry land." [10] Then the men feared with a great fear and said to him, "What is this you have done!" For the men knew that he was fleeing from the face of the LORD, because he had told them. [11] And they said to him, "What shall we do to you, so that the sea will calm down for us?" For the sea was growing more and more stormy. [12] He said to them, "Pick me up and hurl me into the sea, and the sea will calm down for you. For I know that it is on my account that this great storm has come upon you." [13] The men rowed hard to get back to dry land, but they could not, for the sea was growing more and more stormy against them. [14] Then they called out to the LORD and said,

"Please, LORD, do not let us perish for this man's life, and do not lay innocent blood on us! For you, LORD, have done as you pleased." 15 Then they picked Jonah up and hurled him into the sea, and the sea stopped its raging. 16 Then the men feared the LORD with a great fear; they offered a sacrifice to the LORD and made vows.

Chapter 2

1 But the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah. And Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights. (*English Bibles*: 1:17) 2 Then Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from the belly of the fish 3 and said:

I called out of my distress to the LORD,
and he answered me;
from the belly of the grave I cried for help –
you heard my voice.
4 You had thrown me into the deep,
into the heart of the seas,
and the current surrounded me;
all your breakers and your waves
passed over me.
5 And I – I said, "I am driven away
from before your eyes.
Yet I will look again
towards your holy temple."
6 Waters closed around me up to my throat,
the deep surrounded me,
seaweed was wrapped around my head.
7 To the roots of the mountains I went down;
the earth – its bars closed behind me for ever.
But you brought my life up from the pit,
LORD my God.
8 When my soul was fainting within me,
I remembered the LORD,
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
9 Those who cling to worthless idols

abandon their faithful love.
10 But I, with a voice of thanksgiving,
will sacrifice to you;
what I have vowed I will pay.
Salvation belongs to the LORD!

11 Then the LORD spoke to the fish, and it vomited Jonah out onto the dry land.

Chapter 3

1 The word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time: 2 "Get up, go to Nineveh, the great city, and cry out to it the message that I am telling you." 3 So Jonah got up and went to Nineveh, as the LORD had said. Now Nineveh was a great city – great even before God – a three days' journey across. 4 Jonah began to go into the city, one day's journey, and he cried out and said, "Forty more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!" 5 And the people of Nineveh believed God. They called a fast and put on sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least. 6 When the word reached the king of Nineveh, he got up from his throne, took off his royal robe, covered himself with sackcloth, and sat in the ashes. 7 And he had it cried out in Nineveh and said: "By decree of the king and his great men: let neither man nor beast, herd nor flock taste anything; let them not graze, and let them not drink water. 8 Let man and beast be covered with sackcloth, and let them call out to God with all their strength. Let each one turn from his evil way and from the violence that is in his hands. 9 Who knows? God may turn and relent; he may turn from his burning anger, so that we do not perish." 10 And God saw what they did, that they turned from their evil way. And God relented of the evil that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it.

Chapter 4

1 But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil – and his anger burned. 2 He prayed to the LORD and said, "Please, LORD, is this not what I said while I was still in my own country? That is why I fled to Tarshish in the first place. For I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love, and one who relents over evil. 3 So now, LORD, please take my life from me, for my death is better than my life." 4 But the LORD said, "Is it

right for your anger to burn?" [5] Jonah went out of the city and sat down east of the city. There he made himself a shelter and sat under it in the shade, until he could see what would happen in the city. [6] Then the LORD God appointed a leafy plant and made it grow up over Jonah, to be shade over his head, to deliver him from his evil. And Jonah rejoiced over the plant with great joy. [7] But God appointed a worm when dawn came up the next day, and it struck the plant, so that it withered. [8] When the sun rose, God appointed a scorching east wind, and the sun struck Jonah's head, so that he grew faint. He asked that he might die, and said, "My death is better than my life." [9] But God said to Jonah, "Is it right for your anger to burn over the plant?" He said, "It is right for my anger to burn – to the point of death!" [10] Then the LORD said, "You had pity on the plant, for which you did not labour and which you did not make grow; it came into being in a night and perished in a night. [11] And should I not have pity on Nineveh, the great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand people who do not know their right hand from their left – and many animals as well?"